

In Search Of Search

HOW OFTEN, while searching the Net, have you found exactly what you are looking for? Chances are, not often enough. And if you only look at the very first result, perhaps less than one per cent of the time. Searching for relevant information on the WWW is akin to spotting weeds in your garden. The information is buried under so many layers of unwanted or sometimes even sponsored content, it becomes a highly frustrating exercise to get to your desired page or site.

When I tried searching for a friend's Web presence lately, all I got was a deluge of sites carrying reference to the politician "Varun Gandhi" and not my school buddy. Granted, my friend shares his name with a famous personality, but I would like the option to omit the politician from my results, without having to add "-politician -bjp -politics" to my search term. Why can't engines distinguish between the politician and my friend? Personally, I would like something like Wikipedia's "disambiguation" option for my searches.

What we need are filters that can separate the wheat from the chaff—using intelligent search mechanisms to do the job!

It is this very inadequacy of existing search engines that has spawned the increasing usage of social or community search engines. Similar services are also now being offered by Yahoo! and Google.

The new generation of search services doesn't just offer personalisation of your search, but also lends the option of customising the search topics as well as how results are served up on your first attempt.

With more than 25 billion pages of Web content out there, search engines have lately realised the fact that users also want to personalise the information they are getting—Google, for example, offers personalised searching, and several other search engines allow a certain level of user intervention with search results.

A number of new services also provide the ability to create your very own search engine. Services like Rollyo, the Yahoo! Search Builder, PSS! and Eurekster's Swicki claim to create a search function for users, but they all do it somewhat differently.



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Admittedly, these personalised search services have their own advantages and disadvantages, and are far from being perfect. Some are limited by their scope of search, while others are unfriendly when it comes to user interface or customisation. “None of them stand head and shoulders above the others” says Phil Bradley of searchenginewatch.com, who reviewed these for efficacy. While there are numerous such options today, we are still far, far away from the near-perfect crawler that can tell the difference between the “bush” in “bush fire” and news results about US President Bush!

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink.

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